

Tillson T3

Indicators & Analysis / Trend | intermediate | 4 min read | DeepCharts Help Center | July 16, 2026

The Tillson T3 is an advanced smoothing indicator developed by Tim Tillson. It behaves like a moving average but applies multiple layers of smoothing, which gives it a noticeably smoother line with less lag than a simple or exponential moving average of the same length.

If you already use a standard Moving Average and find it either too jumpy or too slow, the T3 is the natural next step: it filters noise without falling as far behind price.

What it is

The T3 answers the question "which way is price really going once the noise is stripped out?" It plots a single smoothed line on the price chart. Because of its construction, the line turns with price sooner than a conventional moving average of comparable smoothness — that lag reduction is the whole point of the indicator. To feel the lag trade-off the T3 improves on, toggle between SMA and EMA and drag the length slider in the demo below.

[WIDGET: ma-lab]

A **Volume Factor** setting controls the balance between responsiveness and smoothness, so one indicator can be tuned from "fast signal line" to "slow trend filter" without changing its length.

When to use it

- As a trend filter: trade only in the direction of the T3 slope.
- As a dynamic support/resistance reference in trending markets, similar to how traders use an EMA.
- As a smoother replacement for a moving average in crossover setups, when a regular MA whipsaws too often.
- On volatile instruments or fast intraday timeframes where a raw moving average produces too much noise.

Quick start

1. Open a chart and click the bar-chart icon in the top-left corner to open the **Indicators** panel.
2. Click **Indicators** to open the full **Indicator List**.
3. Search for "Tillson T3" and click + to add it.
4. Click the gear icon next to the indicator to open its settings.

A sensible starter configuration is the default one: **Length** 14, **Volume Factor** 0.618, **Input Data** Close. With **Auto Color** set to **Slope**, the line changes color as its direction changes, which makes the trend read at a glance.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER] A price chart with the Tillson T3 plotted over the candles, Auto Color = Slope so the line shows one color on rising segments and the secondary color on falling segments `tillson-t3-on-chart.png`

How to read it

- **Slope** is the primary signal. A rising T3 indicates upward pressure; a falling T3 indicates downward pressure. With **Auto Color: Slope** enabled the color flip marks each direction change.
- **Price relative to the line:** price holding above a rising T3 supports a long bias; price holding below a falling T3 supports a short bias.
- **Flattening line:** when the T3 goes flat and price crosses it repeatedly, the market is ranging — trend-following signals from any moving average are unreliable in that state.

Because the T3 is heavily smoothed, treat it as a trend and bias tool rather than a precise entry trigger. Combine it with a momentum tool such as RSI or with orderflow context for timing.

Settings reference

General

Setting	What it does
Length	Number of bars used in the smoothing process. Default: 14. Shorten it for faster timeframes, lengthen it for higher-timeframe trend filtering; adjust to your instrument's volatility.
Volume Factor	Controls smoothing strength, typically in the range 0 to 1. Default: 0.618 (the golden ratio). Lower values make the line more responsive with less lag; higher values increase smoothing strength, producing a smoother line that filters out more noise.
Input Data	Which price series feeds the calculation: High (sensitive to upward movements), Low (sensitive to downward movements), Open (initial bar price), Close (default — the bar's settlement price), or Volume (volume-weighted analysis). See Different Types of Input Data for Indicators.

Subgraph

Setting	What it does
Color / Secondary Color	The bullish and bearish line colors used when auto-coloring is active.
Subgraph Style	How the series is drawn. Default: Line .
Auto Color	Set to Slope to recolor the line automatically based on the indicator's direction.
Line Style	Default: Solid ; dashed alternatives are available.
Line Width	Line thickness. Default: 1. Increase it to make the trend line more prominent.
Short Name	Custom label shown in the chart legend.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER] The Tillson T3 settings dialog showing the General group (Length 14, Volume Factor 0.618, Input Data Close) and the Subgraph group below it [tillson-t3-settings.png](#)

Tips and common mistakes

- **Do not tune Length and Volume Factor at the same time.** Change one, observe, then change the other — both affect smoothness, and adjusting them together makes it hard to tell which change helped.
- **A smoother line is not automatically better.** Pushing the Volume Factor high makes the T3 very clean but also slower to confirm reversals. Match the setting to your holding time.
- **Ranging markets defeat every moving average**, including the T3. If the line is flat, stand aside or switch to range tools instead of taking every crossover.
- Compare it side by side with a standard Moving Average of the same length once — seeing the lag difference on your own instrument is the fastest way to understand what the T3 buys you.

Related articles

- Moving Average
- Super Trend

- Linear Regression
- Different Types of Input Data for Indicators
- How to Change the Layout of Indicators